The Difficult-Point Commentary on Glorious Hevajra Called Extracting the Vajra Words

Śrī Hevajrasya Vajrapadoddharaṇa Nāma Pañcikā · Toh 1192 · Derge Tengyur
དཔལ་དགྱེ་པའ་རྡོ་རྗེའི་ཀ་འགལ་འགལ་ར་རྡོ་རྗེ་ཚིག་བཏུ་ཁྲ་ཞེས་བྱ་

The Difficult-Point Commentary on Glorious Hevajra Called Extracting the Vajra Words, known in Sanskrit as Śrī Hevajrasya Vajrapadoddharaṇa Nāma Pañcikā and in Tibetan as Pal Gyepé Dorjé Kadrel Dorjé Tsik Tuwa, is a commentary on the Hevajra Tantra, one of the principal scriptures of the yoginī or mother tantras. After verses of homage to Hevajra and to the author's gurus, it singles out key "vajra words" from selected chapters of both parts of the tantra and explains their inner meaning. Among its themes are the innate bliss realized through completion-stage yoga, the purpose of the tantric empowerments, and the difference between the example gnosis and the actual gnosis to which it points. Its colophon names the great master Kāmadhenupa as its author. It is Toh 1192 in the Tengyur, where it is placed among the commentaries on the tantras.

In Sanskrit: śrī hevajrasya vajrapadoddharaṇa nāma pañcikā. In Tibetan: The Difficult-Point Commentary on Glorious Hevajra Called Extracting the Vajra Words.

Homage to glorious Hevajra.

Homage to the one who does not abide in saṃsāra, yet roams in saṃsāra.
Homage to the one who pacifies fear, yet produces fear.
Homage to the one free of attachment, whose very self is desire.
Homage to the dispeller of darkness, who is like black darkness.

Those through whose kindness my mind has entered into virtue
And come to possess the refuge of peerless wisdom,
All those, however many, who have become gurus in saṃsāra:
Having reverently taken the dust of their feet upon the crown of my head,
Of this glorious king of tantras, Hevajra,
The vajra words that the wise have concealed,
In order to turn back clinging to their literal sense,
I shall extract a few and make them clear.

Now, the perfect and complete Buddha said, "Compile my scriptures with an introduction, beginning 'Thus did I hear at one time.'" Therefore the compiler, the bodhisattva Vajragarbha, here sets out the introduction: "Thus did I hear at

one time: the Blessed One was dwelling in the bhaga of the vajra queens of the body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas." This passage, set down at the very beginning, I shall first explain according to the common system, as the words that express the excellences.

Here, "thus" is the answer to a question. For the bodhisattvas asked the bodhisattva Vajragarbha, "Speak just as you heard it from the Blessed One," and he answered, "What I am about to explain, I heard thus from the Blessed One." "I" shows that what was heard thus was heard directly, and not passed down from one person to another. "Heard" means that it was made an object of the ear consciousness. By this he does not claim to have made it a matter of direct perception, since that is the domain of the Omniscient One alone. "At one time" expresses the thought: "I did not listen to this again and again; at other times I heard other things, and at one time I heard this." Therefore these words, "Thus did I hear at one time," show, in order, the excellence of the compiler through four qualities: not engaging rashly, holding it well, being a direct disciple of the Teacher, and having great learning.

The excellence of time is shown by the very words "at one time." For during the eighty years that the Blessed One's emanation body dwelt in Jambudvīpa, he did not teach this precious tantra again and again; he taught it only once, at one time. Therefore its time is indeed more exalted than any other time. Likewise, because this is hard to find, it also aptly expresses the excellence of the teaching itself. Thus it is said:

In the world the omniscient ones
Are like the udumbara flower:
Though now and then, once in a long while,
They may appear, mostly they do not.
The appearance of the way of secret mantra conduct
Is rarer even than that.

To set forth the excellence of the Teacher, it says "the Blessed One" (Bhagavān, in Tibetan the Vanquishing, Endowed, Transcendent One). Because he has vanquished the foe, the four māras, he is the Blessed One by an etymology drawn from his deeds, and it is by him that this was taught. Or else, wisdom, in the sense that it conquers the afflictions, is indicated by the word "vanquishing," and because he possesses it, he is the Blessed One. Or else, he is the Blessed One because he is free of fear, as is said in the noble Irreversible Wheel:

Though he teaches embodied beings
Phenomena that are like space,
In this he has no fear;
Therefore he is called the Blessed One.

Or else, he is the Blessed One because he possesses infinite qualities. This very point is what this tantra itself calls the six qualities, which will be explained as "all the qualities, lordship and the rest." Or else, he is the Blessed One because he is free of both existence and nirvāṇa, since his nature is the permanent, nonabiding nirvāṇa. These are offered as alternative explanations, not as expressions of doubt.

To express the excellence of the retinue, it mentions "all the Tathāgatas," "body, speech, and mind," and "the vajra queens." That is, the meaning is: "I heard it together with the transmundane retinue: all the Tathāgatas, Vairocana and the rest; the bodhisattvas of body, speech, and mind vajra, Kṣitigarbha and the rest, comprised in three classes; and the vajra queens, the yoginī Nairātmyā and the rest." Likewise, it was also together with the worldly retinue, for in the Ḍākinīvajrapañjara, the thirty-second section of this very tantra, the words of rejoicing mention a retinue of gods and others. If one asks why this was not stated in that way at the beginning, it is not needed, since it is established by its counterpart: that they were indeed assembled is understood precisely by way of the counterpart.

To make clear the excellence of the place, it says "bhaga." The square, four-doored, multistoried mansion, which is not inert matter because its nature is gnosis, adorned with the distinctive features of transmundane conditions, and arisen from the cause of immeasurable merit: that is the bhaga, and it is there that he dwelt. If one asks where this is: to those who are fortunate, these very ordinary places, Rājagṛha and the rest, appear in that way. Some say, "The path that involves desire was taught in the abode of the Paranirmitavaśavartin gods," and for that very reason they say, "The bhaga is the celestial palace of multistoried chambers on the summit of Mount Meru, and it was there." Others say, "This was taught by the enjoyment body, and that dwells in Akaniṣṭha, the summit of the form realm; so the bhaga is precisely the buddha field Ghanavyūha, which extends throughout all immeasurable grounds and whose bounds have become the domain of the Tathāgatas, and it was there."

"Was dwelling" means that he dwelt in the four postures, in keeping with the domain of those to be trained. Thus, from "Thus did I hear" up to "was dwelling," the six kinds of excellence of this king of tantras have been well taught.

Now, the introduction of the tantra is explained by way of showing the excellence of the compiler. Here, "all the Tathāgatas" are Vairocana and the rest. Their body, speech, and mind are the indivisible vajra, and these very ones have thus become the queens on account of those to be trained. Their bhaga is the multistoried mansion of Dharma suited to teaching the Dharma that is the highest of the high, and it is in that. "Was dwelling" is as before. If one asks who was dwelling, it is the Blessed One, as before. If one asks what distinctive qualities he possesses, that is why it says "Thus... I" (evaṃ mayā): he possesses the four immeasurables. "Heard" means coming to be endowed with them. "At one time" means in a single instant. Therefore, what is shown is this: when the compiler directly realized, in a single instant, the Blessed One endowed with the four immeasurables dwelling in the bhaga of the queens, the compiler was professing himself omniscient.

Now the second way is stated, by which the introduction of the tantra delights people given to desire. Here, "thus" is:

The Teacher, with the thirty-two marks,
The Lord, whose body bears the eighty minor marks.

"I" means: by a mind possessed of desire. "Heard" means taught. "At one time" means on one occasion. "The Blessed One" is the conventional awakening mind (bodhicitta), which is like the kunda (jasmine) flower. As for "of all the Tathāgatas," the body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas are themselves vajra by way of nonconceptual meditative absorption. And these very ones have become the queens because they train beings through great desire. Their bhaga resembles the letter e, and it is in the multistoried mansions located there. "Was dwelling" means that, by not abandoning the two aspects, he dwells in keeping with training, through great desire, those who are to be trained. For it is said:

The Teacher, with the thirty-two marks,
The Lord, whose body bears the eighty minor marks,
In the bhaga of the queen, in Sukhāvatī,
Dwells under the name of semen.
Without it there would be no bliss;

Without bliss, it would not exist.

Now the introduction of the tantra is also explained by expressing the excellence of the Teacher. Thus, "thus" is the Dharma body; "I" is the enjoyment body; "heard" is the emanation body; "at one time" is the arising of coemergent joy; and "the Blessed One" is the nature of great bliss, in which the three bodies are indivisible. This is stated:

I am the expounder, and mine is the Dharma;
Endowed with my own qualities, I am the listener.

"The vajra queens of the body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas" is as before. "In their bhaga" has the meaning of what is said here:

The bhaga of the sublime vajra queen
Is like the shape of the letter e;
It is the jewel casket of the buddhas,
Sukhāvatī, my temple.

"Was dwelling" means in accord with the minds of the three kinds of retinue. These make the explanation of the tantra's introduction fourfold.

I shall also state the purpose and so forth of this tantra, which possesses such an introduction. This text, beginning "Thus did I hear," is the expression. The entire collection of meanings that it properly teaches is the subject matter. That these stand as cause and effect is what is called the relation, since they depend on each other. Relying on these, with sound understanding coming first, the purpose extends up to the accomplishment of the culmination of the three bodies. The arising of benefit for others for as long as saṃsāra lasts is here the purpose of the purpose, namely nonabiding nirvāṇa. Thus it is said:

Perfect benefit for others is declared
To be the chief of a buddha's fruits;
Buddhahood and the rest, beside that,
Are called the fruits that serve its aim.

This is the statement of the purpose and the rest.

Now I shall extract the vajra words of the first chapter. As for:

Abiding in the body, and great gnosis,
Through abandoning all conception,
It pervades all things;

Though abiding in the body, it is not born of the body,

"Abiding in the body" refers to the revival as the Tathāgata with an object of focus. "Great gnosis" refers to the revival, without an object of focus, as the great Vajradhara. "Through abandoning all conception" means by way of nonconceptual meditative absorption. "It pervades all things" means that it acts in all things for the benefit of beings. "Though abiding in the body" means even though it possesses the Dharma, enjoyment, and emanation bodies. "It is not born of the body" means that it does not arise from a body other than those. Thus it is shown that the yogin who abides in the generation stage and the completion stage, and who engages in the happiness of beings in a nonconceptual manner, abides in the three bodies; therefore, though it arises from a different body, it has one's own mind as its cause.

Or else, "abiding in the body" is the essential nature of the form body, whose nature is the Great Seal (mahāmudrā). "Great gnosis" is the embodiment of nonobjectifying method and wisdom. "Through abandoning all conception" means the nature in which all conceptual thought without exception has set. "It pervades all things" is the Dharma body, whose nature is supremely profound, which, without beginning or end, equal to the unequaled, like space, pervades all phenomena. "Though abiding in the body" means though it has the aspect of a body. "It is not born of the body" means that even that body is not known through a body. Thus it is shown: the Dharma body, which embodies the form body and the Dharma body, is indeed the supreme aspect of the three bodies, yet it does not thereby come into being as something embodied.

As for:

By Caṇḍālī, blazing at the navel,
The five Tathāgatas are burned,
Locanā and the rest are burned,
And from haṃ the moon flows down,

"Caṇḍālī" means the untouchable one: she who has the form of the letter oṃ, whose nature is the Perfection of Wisdom, and who cannot be touched by any conceptual thought. She abides in the forms of blazing, spreading, warmth, being thick with smoke, clarity, and so on. "At the navel" means at the hub of the sixty-four-petaled lotus of the emanation wheel.

"Blazing" means that, kindled by fanning and by blazing, it goes like the tip of a lamp flame along the path of the Avadhūtī channel. "The five Tathāgatas are burned" means that next the hūṃ at the hub of the eight-petaled lotus of the Dharma wheel, located at the heart, and the four seeds located on its four petals, are thoroughly burned. "Locanā and the rest are burned" means that the four seeds located on the four intermediate petals of that same wheel are thoroughly burned. Therefore, by burning the conceptual thoughts that are the five buddhas and the four goddesses, who embody the five aggregates and the four elements, one comes to enter the state without appearances. Then again, without interruption, one rises with signs, goes to the wheel of enjoyment, and abides as the enjoyment body. After that, going to the place of great bliss, one thinks, "I have burned all conceptual thought without exception." By thinking this, one is untainted by any distorted conceptual thought, and so the thirty-two drops of the moon, whose nature is the powers, the fearlessnesses, and the unshared qualities, descend and drip into the emanation wheel. That is why it is said, "When haṃ is burned, the moon descends." Here, "haṃ is burned" means that it undergoes burning, for otherwise no basis for the descent of the awakening mind would arise.

The instruction for this is as follows. A yogin abiding in the generation stage should visualize the soles of the feet, as far as the secret place, as the wind maṇḍala. Then, making the secret place together with its surroundings into a triangular fire maṇḍala, that fire goes along the path of the Avadhūtī channel and burns without remainder the eight-petaled lotus of the Dharma wheel at the heart, and one enters the gnosis without appearances. Then again, in the form of light rays, it comes forth along that same path and reaches the throat, and one abides as the enjoyment body in the wheel of enjoyment. Then again, casting off the enjoyment body, it comes forth in the form of light rays along that same path and goes to the wheel of great bliss at the crown of the head. There, touching the white letter haṃ, which rests upside down, it warms it, and goes back downward in the manner of dissolving. Then from haṃ the moon flows down like a little pellet and goes to the places of the wheels; churning the Dharma wheel as well, it goes to the emanation wheel, and is flung back upward as far as the first place. Then, by the sequence of its descending once more, this goes on until it becomes directly manifest. Then one comes to enter the state without appearances.

To clarify this very point, the eighth chapter of the first section says, "Whoever does not know Hevajra." One gazes at the letter aṃ, with light rays of five

colors, set firmly upon the sixty-four-petaled emanation wheel located at the tip of its opening. Then, as wind rises from the wind maṇḍala, the fire maṇḍala blazes, and from the letter aṃ comes a light like the tip of a lamp flame.

Like the flowing current of a river,
Like the unbroken light of a lamp,
Since toil is fruitless,
Through constant union with reality
One should abide day and night.

So it says. Likewise, the fourth chapter of the second section also says:

Abiding in the maṇḍala of the navel,
The very essence of the first vowel,
The intelligent and learned one should contemplate her there.
Here she is the Blessed Lady, Wisdom.
Through the yoga of the completion stage,
She is neither long nor short,
Neither square nor round;
She has neither taste nor smell.
Through producing coemergent joy
The yogin generates her,
And should enjoy her bliss.
The accomplishment of the Great Seal, which bestows bliss,
Comes about together with her.
Form and sound, and likewise smell,
Taste and touch, are likewise here,
As wisdom whose essence is the dharmadhātu (the basic space of phenomena),
Enjoyed to the full.
She is the very substance of coemergent joy;
Here she is the excellent yoga of great bliss.
Here she is the circle of the maṇḍala
And the very essence of the five gnoses:
She is the mirrorlike gnosis
And the gnosis of equality;
She truly becomes the discerning gnosis;
Here she is the accomplishing of activity
And the purity of the dharmadhātu.
Here she is called the lord of the maṇḍala.

Here she is the yoginī Nairātmyā,
The very embodiment of the dharmadhātu.

So it says.

Now here, two kinds of yoga are also branches of this, namely:

The highly elaborate branch
And the condensed branch.

Of these, the highly elaborate branch was made fully clear by the venerable Kṛṣṇapāda in the Four Stages. The condensed branch is stated here:

In the body abide four wheels:
Emanation, Dharma, enjoyment,
And the one called great bliss.
Of these, emanation and enjoyment
Have the nature of wisdom and face upward,
Their hubs well adorned with suns.
Sixty-four and twice eight
Are to be known as the petals of these two.
From their centers, aṃ and oṃ
Send light rays streaming upward.
Likewise, Dharma and great bliss
Have the nature of method and face downward;
Their hubs are adorned with moons,
And at the moons' centers are hūṃ and haṃ.
With eight and thirty-two
Petals these two are made beautiful.
Then leaping and touching,
Hanging, full joining, and blazing,
And again settling and dissolving:
Contemplate it as abiding in the four wisdoms.
By this very sequence,
When the mind has become stable,
One should enter the state without appearances.

This is the instruction for it.

Likewise, at the navel is a red lotus,
Fully opened, with four petals;

On its upward-facing hub
Are the sun, and Wisdom in the form of aṃ.
On its other petals
Are the fourteen vowel letters;
Below, above, and in the intermediate directions too
They are to be imagined. By their blazing,
Lines as fine as the threads of a lotus root
Are drawn by the mind without a break.
When the yogin visualizes these,
In just a few days
He will realize it, without fail.

This too is the condensed branch. It should be understood that completion stages with elaboration such as these serve only for entering the completion stage without elaboration.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the first chapter.

Now I shall enter upon the vajra words of the fifth chapter. As for:

Here, mother, sister, and the rest
Are ever worshiped by one endowed with yoga,

"Here" means on this unsurpassed secret path that involves desire. "Mother" refers to whichever action seal (karmamudrā) has been consecrated as one's consort (vidyā), the wisdom partner. As for "sister and the rest," "sister" is a woman of the same age as oneself who has been consecrated as an action seal. "And the rest" is said in order to include daughter, niece, and so on. These terms too are to be applied to women younger than oneself and so on who have been consecrated as seals, and not taken in their literal sense. For, in order to dispel misunderstanding of what is said in the tantras, the Blessed One taught at length in certain great yoga tantras, in passages such as:

Mother, daughter, sister, and the rest:
One should approach those who are not to be approached.

Therefore the fifth chapter of the second section says:

Mother, daughter, sister,
Niece, maternal aunt, uncle's wife,
Mother-in-law, and one's own father's sister
Are renowned as the eight consorts.

With kisses and close embraces
The yogin should worship them.

This refers to the eight consorts consecrated as the eight goddesses, Gaurī, Caurī, Vetālī, and the rest. Likewise, the seventh chapter of the second section says:

Whoever, to mother and to sister,
To niece and to mother-in-law as well,
Makes the great offering of the feast gathering
Will thereby gain accomplishment.

All such statements are to be regarded as before, and not in their literal sense.

"By one endowed with yoga" means one who has come to abide in the culmination of the meditative absorption of method and wisdom, in which vajra and lotus are consecrated. "Ever worshiped" means to give satisfaction with the bliss of union for as long as one has not attained the state free of elaboration.

Here, then, is the condensed meaning. One takes women of suitable age and so on, indicated by the code terms "mother" and the rest, and purifies them well, and purifies oneself as well. Then, with the bliss of union with her, one satisfies the deity maṇḍalas, which are the aggregates, elements, and sense sources that make up the body. After that, one should please them with the unsurpassed offering, in which the mind has reached the interior of the vajra jewel. When one is well established in the unsurpassed offering, one should not undertake the offering of the bliss of union with her, but should abide in the unsurpassed offering alone. Thus it is said:

Having renounced and cast aside the woman,
One cultivates the gnosis seal.
Once gnosis is accomplished, then
Through the Great Seal awakening is accomplished.

It is also said:

Through this secret union,
One should not look to outer union.

Therefore, union with the action seal and with the gnosis seal is taught for those who are unable to enter into union with the Great Seal, but not for those who are able to enter into union with the Great Seal. Therefore, the teaching

on the Great Seal in the eighth chapter of the second section, beginning "Neither too tall nor too short," was given out of great compassion solely to draw in those of lesser capacity, by means of an illustration that, as it is explained, teaches emptiness. If it were not so, what would be the use of the completion stage without elaboration?

As for:

The bliss, such as it is, obtained from the father,
One experiences that bliss oneself.
That by which one dies is also bliss;
That bliss is called meditative concentration,

"Father": the aspect of mind-only is what is called father. The bliss, such as it is, obtained from that father is simply the bliss whose characteristic is benefiting all sentient beings. "One experiences that bliss oneself" means that one should realize one's own self, the essence of unsurpassed emptiness and compassion, as fully awakened from beginningless time. If one asks what that bliss is like, that is why it says, "That by which one dies is also bliss." The bliss by which one dies: the cessation of the life wind that drives the exertions of body, speech, and mind is that by which one dies. If one asks what that leads to, it says, "that bliss of one's own": it is the nature of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. "Meditative concentration," because it is nonconceptual and one-pointed. "Is called" signifies that what has been explained in this way is conventional. Thus it is shown: having realized all phenomena as mind-only, and putting great love first toward those who lack that realization, one enters the state without appearances, which is what is taught as "dying," whose essence is the cutting off of ordinary life. One attains perfect awakening, and does not come to abide in the conventional under the name "meditative concentration."

Again, "father" is the mind that embodies wisdom and gnosis. "Such as it is" means according to the accumulations. "Bliss" is the nature of the bliss of the three realms. "Obtained" means found. "One experiences that bliss oneself" means that this unsurpassed bliss, the nature of the Tathāgata, is to be accomplished through meditation alone, without depending on an action seal. "That by which ... bliss" means that it arises by its own nature. "Dies" means that the defiled aggregates, elements, and sense sources are put to death through their utter nonarising. "That bliss is called meditative concentration" means that it arises from outstanding meditative concentration. That very

bliss is the nature of Vajradhara, great bliss. "Is called" means that the gurus say that it arises and is born from one's own mind alone.

What this says is the following. That source of bliss, the mind whose nature is the yogin's wisdom and gnosis, has through good and bad accumulations become beings both excellent and inferior, and the means of attaining the realization that great bliss is undivided in all of them is one's own mind alone. Therefore the holy gurus have said that the arising of bliss by its own nature, the attainment of the cessation of defiled phenomena, comes from training in outstanding meditative concentration. This is explained here according to the oral instructions; that is why the tenth chapter of the first part says, "Free from the cause that is the seal." That is to say, people who are endowed with the legs of wisdom and compassion do not need, even at the outset, the secret empowerment, the wisdom gnosis empowerment, or the fourth; and later too, apart from the Great Seal (mahāmudrā) free from conceptual elaboration, they have no need at all to rely on any other seal. That being so, they are untouched by the fault of desire, and they also abide in the means that liberates through desire; therefore they have also obtained the authority to hold and to give the oral instructions on the matters of the secret and of wisdom gnosis.

Someone may object: How could it be that they,
while lacking empowerment,
have gained the authority to hold its oral instructions
and to give them? If that were so,
"To one who is rightly empowered
reality should be taught, said Vajradhara;
otherwise for him accomplishment
does not exist, and there will be no awakening,"
and the like would not hold true either.

That is not so. For example, just as those who have not experienced the painful sensation of having their eyes opened with an eye salve probe are not without the authority to hold and to give the knowledge of the probe, so it is in this case too.

Suppose someone says: That is not so, for here it is an experiential meaning that is being taught. That is not so, because it is said:
"Innate joy cannot be told by others,
and though it is not found anywhere,"

and likewise, since it is said:
"Like the great joy of a young maiden,
a bliss arises that cannot be shown,"
one does not describe to the disciple one's own experience just as it is.

Moreover, if one speaks of an experiential meaning, does one speak of the experience of the bliss that arises from the two organs, or else of the realization of gnosis free from conceptual elaboration? It is not the first, because that does not depend on a guru and arises in all who are free from desire. Nor is it the second, because it would then follow that it does not depend on attaining it, and that even some who lack the aspects of the perfections would accomplish it. As for the words that were spoken, beginning "To one who is rightly empowered," they do not refute this at all, because the intent of the knowledge empowerment and all its domains have not been grasped.

Suppose someone says: That may be so, but this is not reasonable. Since the knowledge empowerment is the purification of the body, while the secret and the wisdom gnosis empowerments are the purification of speech and mind, for one on whom the knowledge empowerment has been conferred only the body is purified, not mind and speech.

That may be so, but this is a matter of the greatest confusion: it merely depends on the dispositions of individuals and is not fixed at all. Were it otherwise, the knowledge empowerment would be wholly impaired, for it is said that the water, the crown, the vajra, the bell, and the name respectively accomplish the mirrorlike gnosis, the gnosis of equality, the discriminating gnosis, the gnosis that accomplishes activities, and the gnosis of the utterly pure dharmadhātu. Moreover, if even when the purification of the five gnoses had reached its culmination, speech and mind remained unpurified, who would strive in this teaching? Therefore whoever has received the knowledge empowerment indeed has authority over the three kinds of empowerment.

Suppose someone says: In that case these would not be taught, for they would be pointless. The denial is not applied in every case. It is like the way that, in some cases, showing an empty fist proves a better means than a pure pearl necklace.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the fifth chapter.

Now I shall begin Extracting the Vajra Words of the sixth chapter.

At the foot of a lone tree or in a charnel ground,
meditation is declared to be wholesome;
likewise at night in the house of the mother goddesses (mātṛkās),
or else in a solitary place and on the outskirts.
Having gained a little heat,
whoever wishes should engage in the conduct.

Here, "a lone tree" is the body itself, which has many branches such as the arms. "Charnel ground" is one's own body itself, as this very text says:
"That which is fully endowed with breath
is called a charnel ground."
The seven constituents are the mātṛkās, and their gathering is the house of the mātṛkās; therefore that too is one's own body itself. Night is the time when desire and the like have fallen asleep. A solitary place is one where conceptual thoughts do not stir. "Outskirts" means in the center of the lotus. "Meditation is declared to be wholesome" praises meditating on the completion stage through union with a wisdom consort who is like one's own body. What this teaches is that, with one's own body free of ordinary desire and the like and free of bad conceptual thoughts, one should place the vajra in the center of the consort's lotus and meditate as the oral instructions direct. The power by which one who has toiled at yoga and found a special capacity is not harmed by adversities is called heat; and since that is not fully complete, it says "having gained a little." Even those who have thus gained heat do not necessarily engage in the conduct; since this depends on their own wish, it says, "whoever wishes should engage in the conduct." Explained according to the literal sense of the words, these are easy to understand.

One should always drink compassion
as the cause of benefit for all sentient beings.
The yogin who delights in drinking yoga
is not intoxicated by any other drink.

Here, "always" means at all times. "Compassion" means wishing to dispel the suffering of all sentient beings. "Should drink" means that, having become the enjoyment body and the emanation body, one teaches the Dharma to the whole world and so leads it into the city of nonabiding nirvāṇa. For that very reason it says, "as the cause of benefit for all sentient beings." Yoga is the gnosis in which means and wisdom are nondual, and this very gnosis is also a drink, because it is what the holy ones desire and strive for. The yogin who

delights in drinking it will attain the Dharma body. This is the side of what is to be adopted.

Teaching the other side, it says, "is not intoxicated by any other drink." That is, no drink other than the nectar drink of emptiness and compassion brings intoxication, meaning that no other drink leads to the attainment of the Dharma body. As it is said: "If one delights in accomplishing a bodily form with the major and minor marks, this is not exerting diligence. Rather, one comes to delight in accomplishing full realization through the Dharma by which the unshared qualities of a buddha and the rest operate spontaneously."

Alternatively, "One should always drink with compassion" means that at all times, with great compassion going before, one should bless liquor and the like into the water of nectar, and, with the identification of oneself as the deity, one should drink them, that is, partake of them. "The continuum for the benefit of all sentient beings" means that all the body and speech the yogin has should be used for that alone when bringing sentient beings into the supreme vehicle. Yoga is the samādhi of means and wisdom. Delighting in drinking it is keeping it in mind constantly, without interruption. "Yogin" means one who knows all the ways of the commitments and of samādhi without exception. "By other things not to be drunk" refers to whatever impairs the commitments, such as guarding against acts that make beings lose faith, and is far removed from the way of means and wisdom. "Intoxicates" means that, preceded by distraction, they intoxicate body, speech, and mind, so that one becomes like someone who has fainted. As it is also said:

To give rise to the identification,
so that gnosis does not faint,
with a mind of sublime joy
one should accustom oneself to only a little.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the sixth chapter.

Now I shall begin Extracting the Vajra Words of the tenth chapter. "In supreme joy, what is to be meditated on" refers to the supporting maṇḍala, which has such qualities as being square; it is to be construed with "does not exist." "Nor is there a meditator" means that the deities arranged within it as the nine deities and so on, the supported maṇḍala, do not exist. "No body, no object grasped, and no grasping subject either" means that the five, Vajrā and the rest, whose nature is the aggregate of form and the rest; the six, Gaurī and the rest, whose nature is form and the rest; and the six, Mohavajrā and the rest,

whose nature is the eye and the rest, do not exist. "No flesh, no blood, no excrement or urine" means that the four boundary guardians, Dhūpā and the rest, do not exist. "No lamenting, and no bewilderment either" and "there is no bathing and no cleanliness" mean that Locanā, Māmakī, Pāṇḍaravāsinī, and Tārā do not exist.

"No attachment, no aversion, no delusion,
no envy, no slander, no pride"

means that the universal monarchs of the six families, Akṣobhya, Māyājāla, Vajrasūrya, Padmanarteśvara, Vajra Swift-Goer, and Paramādya, do not exist. "Meditation, what is meditated, and the like" refers to the path and what relies on it; this is to be construed with "does not exist." "Enemies and friends" refers to the afflictions, whose nature is to be destroyed, and the qualities of a buddha, which are to be taken up; these too are to be construed with "do not exist."

"The innate is declared to be without waves;
it is free from variety."

Here, the waves are conceptual thoughts, whose nature is to arise when stirred on the river of objects by the wind of conditions. That in which they are cut off is explained to be the exemplified innate, free from conceptual elaboration. For that very reason, because this is the subsiding of the variety of thoughts, peaceful like the continuous flame of a lamp where there is no wind, and because it is selflessness, being gnosis free from awareness of self and other, it is said, "it is free from variety." It is an innate of this kind that one should desire. One should not long for the bliss of the example innate, born from the two organs, which one experiences just as all childish people do.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the tenth chapter of the first part.

Now I shall begin Extracting the Vajra Words of the second part. It says:

At night in one's own house,
one should think, "I am accomplished."

Since one takes up the five aggregates through one's own conceptual thought, those five aggregates, together with craving, are one's own house. "Night" means that the village of the senses has fallen asleep, so that they do not engage their objects. "One should think, I am accomplished" means that, being free from ordinary conceptual thought, one should think, "I am the accomplished being, glorious Heruka or the like." As it is also said:

To destroy the ordinary aspect,
one should identify oneself as the deity.

To destroy that identification as well,
one should meditate on the objectless.
When the mind too abides in evenness,
then it is certainly reality itself.
The way the identification is made is also stated:
The yogin who is a beginner
should become familiar with the emanation body.
When the emanation has become stable,
one should meditate on the enjoyment body, making it stable.
When the emanation body has become clear,
and as soon as the enjoyment body is clear,
this Dharma body without object
is what has been stated in brief.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the second chapter.

Now I shall begin Extracting the Vajra Words of the fourth chapter.
The bliss of entering is the Great Seal;
the vajra, the sense source, is the means.
Here, entering is the vajra. Its bliss is the gnosis of bliss that has gone inside the jewel. That very gnosis is the Great Seal, because it seals all phenomena as having a single nature. The vajra is nonreferential gnosis; because that very gnosis becomes the door through which the wheel of the maṇḍala arises, it is the sense source. "Is the means" means that it brings one near to outstanding gnosis. Alternatively, entering is the vajra, and its bliss is the clarity of sublime bliss, free from extremes. The nature of that gnosis is the Great Seal; the one who has the form of the letter aṃ is the wisdom consort. "Vajra" means indivisible. "Arising" is consciousness, and "spreading" is the sequence of contraction, enjoyment, and mastery.

"Is the means" means that this, too, leads to the sacred sites (pīṭhas), the secondary sacred sites, and the rest.

As for the passage "They were utterly stunned; terrified, they trembled; and fainting, they fell to the ground": because they understood, "This Dharma, which establishes that the suchness of ordinary beings and the suchness of an unsurpassed, perfectly complete buddha are indivisible, one with the other, is a marvel," it says, "They were utterly stunned." "Terrified" is said because the Great Seal, whose nature is nonabiding nirvāṇa for as long as saṃsāra lasts,

cannot be shown, is hard to realize, and is supremely profound, so that those of weak faith are unable to enter it. "They trembled" means that, on hearing the Dharma called Hevajra, the unsurpassed means that wholly transcends every world, free of hardship and swift, they obtained signs such as trembling. "Fainting" means that, by way of the samādhi that conceives of all phenomena as indivisible, of the nature of great bliss, they brought all mind and mental factors to utter nonarising. "They fell to the ground" means that, on hearing the Dharma of reality, which cuts off the aggregates and the rest together with their habitual tendencies, the lesser ones were shattered, and their whole bodies fell to the ground.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the fourth chapter.

Now I shall begin Extracting the Vajra Words of the eleventh chapter. As for "This gnosis is extremely subtle," the gnosis is right here, because its essential nature, free from inert matter, is constant experience. "Extremely subtle" is said because those of coarse intellect cannot understand it even that far; what need is there even to mention that it is not something they could truly experience at all? "Vajra" is the mind; and because its nature is nonconceptual, it is called "essence." Because that very mind is naturally pure, it is just like the sky at midday in autumn; therefore it says, "like the sky." Because it is without the dust of the afflictions such as desire, it says, "utterly peaceful." Because it bestows the liberation of nonabiding nirvāṇa, it "bestows liberation." Because the obscurations are utterly pacified, it is "utterly peaceful." Because it becomes the means of realizing reality, the guru of gurus, which goes by the name "self-arisen gnosis," it says, "You yourself will become your own father."

What this teaches is that at the time of the fourth empowerment it is said: "Through the guru's oral instructions and the power of your own merit, directly perceive that gnosis in which all conceptual thought has subsided!" This too is to be understood as twofold, divided into directly perceiving the true gnosis and directly perceiving its example gnosis. Otherwise, the example gnosis alone would serve no purpose, and the arising of the exemplified gnosis alone is also impossible, because at first the example must necessarily go before it. Therefore, through the example gnosis this is the lower kind, while through the exemplified gnosis it is truly supreme. For this reason, those who from the very beginning are able to give rise to the exemplified gnosis without relying on the example do not rely on the example gnosis, while some, who would not enter the exemplified without relying on the example gnosis, rely on both.

Here, moreover, a mantra practitioner committed to celibacy should not experience the example gnosis, because, on account of the root of roots, he would be bound for the lower realms together with his guru. Even those who hold, "I am the one who will experience it, not someone else," should not break their first vow; they should properly give it back.

This concludes Extracting the Vajra Words of the eleventh chapter.

Engaging with this glorious king of tantras,
many people of lofty intellect, in many ways,
devoted themselves to many compositions on its meaning
and made many and varied explanations of great clarity.
I have only gathered here the meaning found in them;
nothing at all is said here that did not exist before.
Yet by whatever stainless merit has arisen from this,
may I teach for the welfare of beings in every way.

This completes Extracting the Vajra Words, a commentary on the difficult points of the glorious Hevajra explaining its inner meaning, composed by the great master Kāmadhenupa. It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Vinayadeva and the translator, the monk Chökyi Sherab.

Translator's Notes

• The several explanations of "the Blessed One" play on the Sanskrit bhagavat and on its Tibetan rendering, whose three parts mean vanquished, endowed, and gone beyond; the gloss in parentheses is added so that the wordplay can be followed. The phrase rendered "the thirty-second section of this very tantra" could also be read as "the thirty-two-section version of this very tantra," a reference to the longer Hevajra root tantra; the ordinal reading is followed here. In the udumbara verse, the Tibetan is a terse concessive ("though they may appear, they do not appear"); "mostly" is supplied to bring out its sense.
• The equation of "Thus... I" (evaṃ mayā) with the four immeasurables presumably rests on the four Sanskrit syllables e, vaṃ, ma, yā. "Revival" renders dbugs dbyung ba, literally "causing to breathe again"; it appears to mean the yogin's arising as the deity, with and without an object of focus. In the lemma "of all the Tathāgatas," the Tibetan has the instrumental particle, evidently for the genitive of the root text. In the verse on Caṇḍālī the Tibetan reads "blazing like" (lta bur), but the commentary's own gloss on "at the navel" shows that lte bar is meant, and it is translated so.
• In explaining "haṃ is burned," the commentary uses the verbal noun "burning" rather than the past "burned": haṃ is heated so that it melts, not destroyed, since it must remain the source from which the drop descends, as the instruction that follows confirms. The word qualifying "pellet" (khu 'phang) is obscure and is not rendered. In the quotation from the eighth chapter, the commentary sets its own explanation between the first line, "Whoever does not know Hevajra," and the remaining lines, which include "since toil is fruitless." In the second quotation, grub zhi is read as gru bzhi, "square." The phases named in the verse beginning

"Then leaping and touching," and "the four wisdoms," are technical terms of uncertain exact sense and are rendered literally. "The Four Stages" is taken as the title of a work by Kṛṣṇapāda; the phrase could also mean "in four stages."
• The commentary insists that the kinship terms of the root tantra are code words for consecrated consorts and are not to be taken literally. In the list of the eight consorts, the kinship terms sru mo and me'u mo are rendered "maternal aunt" and "uncle's wife"; their exact correspondence to the Sanskrit list is uncertain. In the quoted line "one should approach," the final syllable byad is read as bya, "should." The closing clause of the summary on "dying" is negative in the Tibetan ("does not come to abide in the conventional"), although the gloss just before calls the name conventional; it is translated as it stands. In the last sentence, 'byung gis skye'o is read as "arises and is born."
• In the root verse of the sixth chapter, the line about the house at night is one syllable short as written. It is translated as "the house of the mother goddesses," the reading the commentary itself gives when it explains the line. As the Tibetan stands, the bliss of the two organs is said to arise "in all who are free from desire." The argument would read more naturally as "all who are not free from desire," so a negative may have been lost; the text is translated as it stands. The empty fist shown to coax a child is a stock image of a skillful expedient.
• In its second explanation of the drinking verse, the commentary cites the lines with slightly different wording: "with compassion," "continuum," "other things not to be drunk," and "intoxicates." It comments on that wording, so the lines are translated as cited. The tenth chapter's closing line reads "first permanence," evidently a slip for "first part," the form used when this chapter was cited earlier; it is translated as "first part." The exemplified innate is the actual innate that the example points to; the example innate is the bliss of the two organs, which only illustrates it. In the fourth chapter, the Tibetan word for sense source (āyatana) literally means "arising and spreading," and the second explanation glosses its two halves separately. The fifth of the six family lords, literally "Vajra Swift-Goer," could not be identified with confidence and is translated literally.
• In the Hevajra system the sacred sites, the secondary sacred sites, and the rest are equated with the stages of the path. The commentary glosses "utterly peaceful" twice. The first gloss, about the dust of the afflictions, probably belongs to the root verse's "free of dust," but it is translated as it stands. "The root of roots" is not explained. It presumably means the most basic vow, here celibacy, whose breach would bring down both the practitioner and his guru. The last line of the closing verse has no explicit wish marker and literally reads "I explain for the welfare of beings in every way"; following the usual form of a dedication, it is rendered as a wish. The Indian preceptor's name is spelled Vinayaṅdeva in the Tibetan and is given here as Vinayadeva.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.